

JJ PREMIER GROUP

GUIDE NO. 01

Flood zones and flood insurance, explained

What a flood zone is, how to find the zone for a house, and what to check before you make an offer.

BY JESSICA GARZA · UPDATED OCTOBER 2, 2026 · 12 MIN READ

How to use this guide

Read this guide once from start to finish. Then use the checklist at the end each time you look at a house.

Maps and rules change. Each drawing names its sources, and the full list is at the end. Before you count on them for one house, check with the county, a surveyor and your insurance agent.

Inside this guide

01 What a flood zone is

02 The three zones you'll hear about most

03 How to find the zone for a house

04 How high the house sits

05 What sets the price of flood insurance

06 When the flood policy starts

07 What the seller has to tell you

08 Before you make an offer

09 Your flood notes for one house

As you read, keep coming back to three questions

1. What flood zone is the house in?
2. How high does the house sit?
3. When will the flood policy start?

01

What a flood zone is

A flood zone is a label on a flood map. It tells you how likely the land is to flood.

Picture the Gulf on a calm, sunny day. Now picture a big storm. Strong wind pushes the water up onto the land. Heavy rain fills the canals and ponds. Some streets stay dry. Others get water in them.

FEMA studies where that water could go. FEMA is the part of the U.S. government that makes flood maps and runs the national flood insurance program. It draws its answer on a flood map. The map splits the land into flood zones, and each zone has a name, like X or AE.

The most important line on the map marks one big flood. It's a flood with a 1 in 100 chance of happening in any year. FEMA calls it the base flood. Some people call it the 100-year flood, but that name gives the wrong idea. It doesn't mean once every 100 years. It means a 1 in 100 chance every single year.

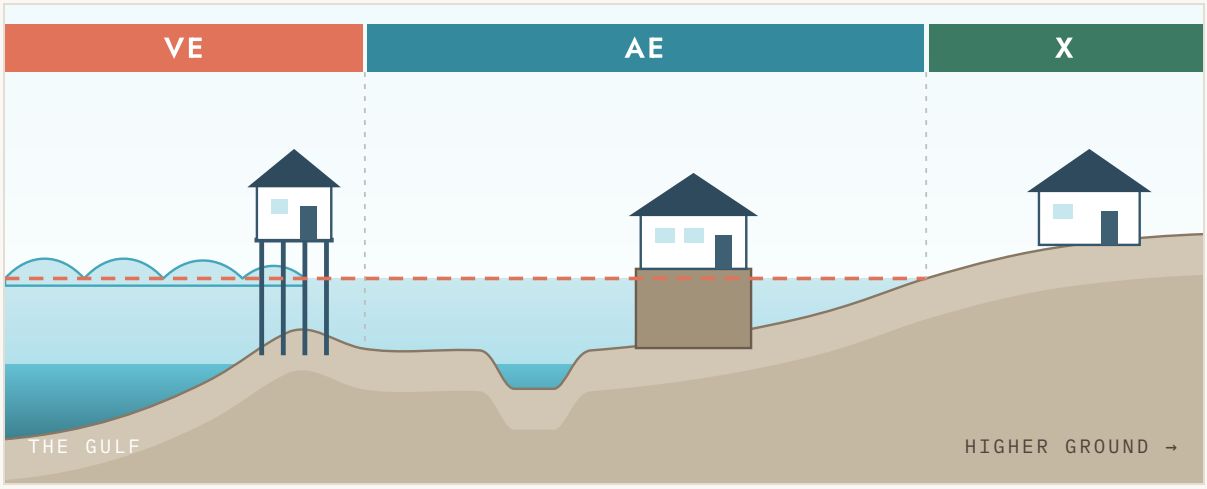
Those chances add up. A home loan often lasts 30 years. Over 30 years, a 1 in 100 chance each year comes to about 1 in 4.

Source: Our arithmetic (the chance of no big flood in 30 years is 0.99 to the 30th power, about 0.74, so the chance of at least one is about 0.26)

FIG. 01 · THE COAST, FROM THE SIDE

From the Gulf to higher ground

Read from left to right. The land gets higher as you move away from the Gulf, and the zone changes with it.



The big flood, a 1 in 100 chance each year

The Gulf on a calm day

VE HIGHEST RISK

The beach and the open bay. In the big flood, waves can be 3 feet tall or more.

AE HIGH RISK

Land the big flood is expected to cover. Any waves here are under 3 feet.

X LOWER RISK

Land that sits above the big flood.

This drawing shows the idea, not a real place. Real zones follow the shape of the land, street by street.

Source: FEMA, Flood zones (glossary); FEMA, Features of flood insurance rate maps in coastal areas

02

The three zones you'll hear about most

This guide covers the three zones you'll hear about most on the coast: VE, AE and X. Each one means something different for you.

VE: the beach and the open bay

VE is the beach and the open bay. In the big flood, waves here can be 3 feet tall or more. That's why new homes in VE must stand up on posts called pilings. The waves can then pass under the house.

AE: where the big flood reaches

AE is land the big flood is expected to cover. Any waves here are under 3 feet. The map shows how high the water would rise. New homes in AE must have the lowest floor at least 1 foot above that height. Some cities and counties require more.

In both VE and AE, you must have flood insurance if your mortgage comes from a lender the U.S. government regulates or backs.

X: higher ground

X is land that sits above the big flood, so the risk is lower. U.S. rules don't require flood insurance here. But a lender can still require it.

Citizens, the state-run home insurance company, can require it too. Most of its home policies that cover wind need flood insurance by January 1, 2027, in any zone. Some need it sooner, based on the home's value. Ask your agent which rule fits the house.

But lower risk isn't no risk. More than 1 in 5 flood insurance claims come from places FEMA rates as low or moderate risk. So we suggest flood insurance in X too.

FIG. 02 · THE THREE ZONES

What each zone means for you

Each card is one zone. Find the one the house is in.

VE

HIGHEST RISK

The beach and the open bay. In the big flood, waves can be 3 feet or more.

IS FLOOD INSURANCE REQUIRED?

Yes, with a mortgage from a lender the U.S. government regulates or backs

HOW NEW HOMES MUST BE BUILT

Up on pilings, so waves can pass under the house

AE

HIGH RISK

Land the big flood is expected to cover. Any waves are under 3 feet.

IS FLOOD INSURANCE REQUIRED?

Yes, with a mortgage from a lender the U.S. government regulates or backs

HOW NEW HOMES MUST BE BUILT

Lowest floor at least 1 foot above the big flood's height. Some places require more, especially near open water

X

LOWER RISK

Higher ground that sits above the big flood.

IS FLOOD INSURANCE REQUIRED?

Not by U.S. rules. But a lender or Citizens can require it, and we suggest it

HOW NEW HOMES MUST BE BUILT

No special flood rules

Some maps show other zones too, like A, AH or AO. If the house is in one of those, ask us what it means. Shaded X is still X, just a little closer to the big flood.

Source: FEMA, Flood zones (glossary); FEMA, Features of flood insurance rate maps in coastal areas; FEMA, Flood insurance; FloodSmart for agents, Flood insurance 101; Citizens Property Insurance, Flood insurance requirement; Florida Building Code flood provisions, 6th and 8th editions

03

How to find the zone for a house

Don't go by the listing. Look up the exact address yourself. It only takes a few minutes.

Flood zones can change from one block to the next, and sometimes from one lot to the next. A listing may show a zone, but someone typed it in by hand. It could be old, or just wrong.

Start with FEMA's flood map website. Type in the address. It shows you the zone, and you can print a small map of that spot. This is the map your lender will use.

Then check with the county. In Manatee County, use the county's flood website, called ForeRunner. Type in the address to see the zone and how high the big flood would reach.

In Sarasota County, start with the City of Sarasota's flood page. It explains the maps and links to the county's flood map. New flood maps took effect there on March 27, 2024. If someone quotes an older map, the zone may have changed.

FIG. 03 · WHERE TO LOOK

Three places to look up a flood zone

Start with FEMA. Then check the county for the house's own records.

01

BOTH COUNTIES

FEMA Flood Map Service Center

Type in the address. See the zone and print a small map of that spot.

MSC.FEMA.GOV

02

MANATEE COUNTY

Manatee County ForeRunner

Type in the address or the parcel number. See the zone and how high the big flood would reach.

MANATEECOUNTYFL.WITHFORERUNNER.COM

03

SARASOTA COUNTY

City of Sarasota flood maps

Read about the maps from March 27, 2024, and open the county's flood map from there.

SARASOTAFL.GOV

In Sarasota County, the city's page links to the county's map tool, so start there.

Source: FEMA Flood Map Service Center; Manatee County, Floodplain management; City of Sarasota, Flood map information

Write down the zone and the date of the map. Papers from different years can show different zones.

04

How high the house sits

Two houses in the same zone can face very different risks. What matters most is how high the floor is.

Picture two houses on the same street. They're the same size and the same age, and they're in the same flood zone. But one sits higher than the other. In a big flood, water is less likely to get inside the higher one. It can cost less to insure, too.

To compare them, you need two numbers. The first is the height the big flood would reach. FEMA calls it the base flood elevation. In AE and VE, you'll find it on the flood map and on the county's flood site.

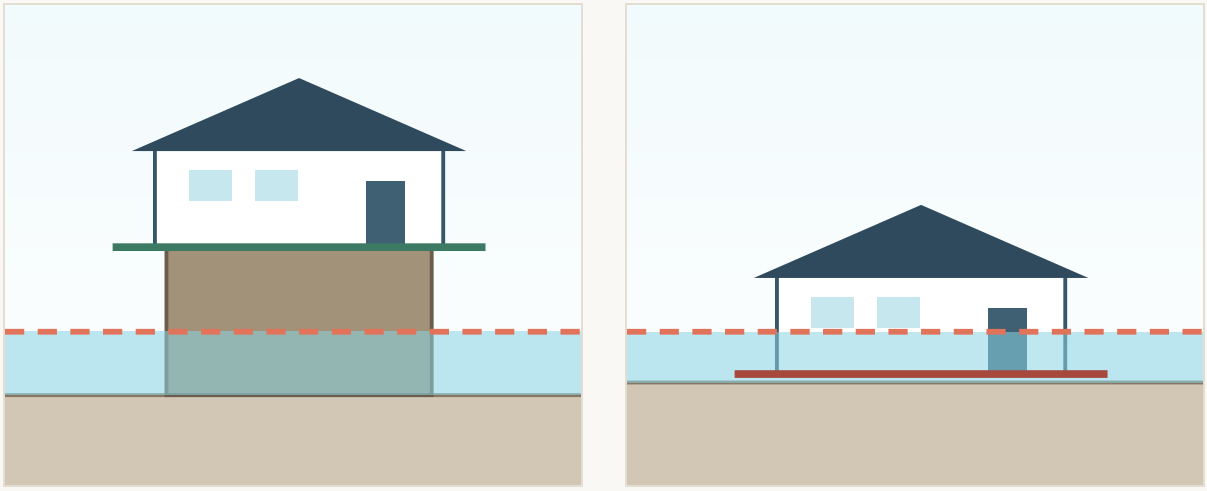
The second is the height of the house's lowest floor. A form called an elevation certificate tells you. A licensed surveyor measures the house and fills it in.

Now compare the two. If the floor is above the flood height, that's good. If it's below, water could come inside in a big flood.

FIG. 04 · TWO HOUSES

Same street, same zone, different floors

The dashed line is how high the big flood would reach. Look at where each floor sits.



House A

Big flood height	9 ft
Lowest floor	11 ft

2 feet above the flood height

The floor is 2 feet above the flood height. Water is less likely to get inside.

House B

Big flood height	9 ft
Lowest floor	8 ft

1 foot below the flood height

The floor is 1 foot below the flood height. In a big flood, water could come inside.

These two houses and their heights are made up to show the idea. A real house has its own numbers, on its own certificate.

Source: The idea: FEMA, Understanding elevation certificates. The houses and their heights are illustrative and are not from any source

ELEVATION CERTIFICATE

A form that shows how high a house sits compared with the big flood. A licensed surveyor, engineer or architect fills it in and signs it.

Source: FEMA, Elevation Certificate and instructions, Form FF-206-FY-22-152, 2022 edition (PDF)

Where to get one

Ask the seller first. They may have a copy. If they don't, ask the county or the city. Manatee County may have one if the home is in a high-risk zone and was built since 1975. The City of Sarasota has the ones made for building permits since the late 1970s. If no one has one, a licensed surveyor can make one for a fee.

A complete, correct certificate doesn't expire. It stays good when the house is sold or the map changes. But check its flood height against the current map, because the map may have changed since. It needs to be redone only if the house or the ground around it changes, like when someone adds a room.

If the seller says it's not in a flood zone

Sometimes a seller says FEMA took the house out of the flood zone. If so, ask for FEMA's letter. It's called a LOMA or a LOMR-F. Only that letter changes what your lender has to require. An elevation certificate on its own doesn't.

05

What sets the price of flood insurance

The zone decides if your lender must require flood insurance. The house and its land decide what FEMA's policy costs.

First, a key fact. A regular homeowners policy doesn't cover flood damage. You need a separate flood policy. You can get one from the National Flood Insurance Program, which FEMA runs, or from a private insurance company.

FEMA changed how it prices its flood policies. It no longer uses the flood zone to set the price. Instead, it looks at the house and its land. How often does it flood there, and from what? How high does the house sit? How close is it to water? What would it cost to rebuild?

You don't need an elevation certificate to buy a FEMA policy anymore. FEMA uses its own data to judge how high the house sits. But if your certificate shows the floor is higher than FEMA thought, the price can go down. So give it to your insurance agent.

In the City of Sarasota, FEMA flood policies get a discount of up to 25 percent. That's because the city does extra work to lower its flood risk.

Ask for a flood quote before you make an offer. The price can change what you can afford each month.

FIG. 05 · WHO DECIDES WHAT

The zone and the house answer different questions

Read each side. The zone answers one question, and the house answers the other.

THE FLOOD ZONE DECIDES

If your lender requires flood insurance

- VE or AE: yes, with a mortgage from a lender the U.S. government regulates or backs
- X: not by U.S. rules, but a lender or Citizens can require it. We suggest it.

THE HOUSE AND ITS LAND DECIDE

What FEMA's flood insurance costs

1. How often it floods there
2. How high the floor sits
3. How close the house is to water
4. The kinds of flooding that can reach it
5. What it would cost to rebuild

Source: FEMA, NFIP's pricing approach (Risk Rating 2.0); FEMA, Flood insurance; Citizens Property Insurance, Flood insurance requirement

06

When the flood policy starts

A new FEMA flood policy usually takes 30 days to start. If you buy it with your home loan, it can start the day you close.

Here's a mistake people make, most often when they pay cash. They buy flood insurance on its own, the week they close on a house. Then they find out it won't start for 30 days. For a whole month, the house has no flood coverage.

There's one big exception. If you buy the policy as part of getting your mortgage, there's no wait. The policy starts when the loan closes. To get this, apply and pay for the policy at or before closing.

If you're paying cash, there's no loan, so the 30-day wait applies. Buy the policy at least 30 days before you close.

Private flood companies set their own rules about waiting. Ask your agent.

FIG. 06 · THE WAIT

How long until a new FEMA flood policy starts

Two ways to buy the same policy. Only one starts on closing day.



One rare case has a 1-day wait. It's for a house that a new flood map just moved into a high-risk zone. It lasts for 13 months after the map changes.

Source: FEMA, Waiting period for a flood policy; 44 CFR 61.11; FloodSmart for agents, Flood insurance 101; Florida Chief Financial Officer, Flood insurance questions

07

What the seller has to tell you

In Florida, the seller has to give you a short flood form by the time you sign the contract. It answers three questions.

Florida law says a home seller must fill out a flood form and give it to the buyer. You get it at or before the time the contract is signed.

The form starts with a reminder that homeowners insurance doesn't cover floods. Then the seller answers three questions, each with a yes or a no.

FIG. 07 · THE SELLER'S FORM

The three questions, in plain words

The seller answers yes or no to each one.

1	**Do you know of any flooding that damaged the home while you owned it?**	☐ YES ☐ NO
2	**Have you ever filed an insurance claim for flood damage to the home?** This includes a claim with FEMA's flood insurance program.	☐ YES ☐ NO
3	**Have you ever received assistance for flood damage to the home?** This includes help from FEMA.	☐ YES ☐ NO

These are plain-language versions of the questions. The real form uses the exact words in Florida law.

Source: Florida Statutes 689.302, as changed by chapter 2025-166, effective October 1, 2025

The form counts more than storm surge as flooding. Water that rises out of the bay, a river or a canal counts. So does water from a river, stream or ditch

that piles up fast, and rain that stands on the land for a long time.

A no answer has limits. It covers only this seller's time in the home. And a seller who never had flood insurance probably has no claim to report. So read the form next to the elevation certificate, and ask questions.

08

Before you make an offer

Use this list each time you look at a house. The first few steps only take a few minutes.

FIG. 08 · THE CHECKLIST

Seven things to check before you make an offer

Go in order. Each step helps with the next one.

- ☐ 01 **Look up the flood zone for the exact address**
  Use FEMA's flood map site or the county's. Don't go by the listing.
- ☐ 02 **Ask the seller for the elevation certificate**
  If there isn't one, ask the county or the city. If they don't have one, a surveyor can make one.
- ☐ 03 **Compare the floor with the flood height**
  Is the lowest floor above or below the big flood? By how much?
- ☐ 04 **If the seller says it's out of the flood zone, ask for FEMA's letter**
  Ask for a LOMA or LOMR-F. Only that letter changes what your lender has to require.
- ☐ 05 **Read the seller's flood form**
  Read it next to the elevation certificate.
- ☐ 06 **Get a flood insurance quote**
  Give the agent the elevation certificate. It can lower the price.
- ☐ 07 **Plan when the policy will start**
  Buy it with your mortgage, applied for and paid by closing. Paying cash? Buy it at least 30 days before closing.

Source: Each step comes from the section it sums up. All sources are listed at the end of this guide

09

Your flood notes for one house

Fill in the right side for the house you're looking at.

Address	Write it here
Flood zone	VE, AE or X
Date of the flood map	From FEMA's site
Big flood height (base flood elevation)	Feet, from the current map. An older certificate may show an old number.
Lowest floor height	Feet, from the certificate
Floor compared with the flood height	Above or below, and by how much. Ask a surveyor if the certificate is older than the map.
Seller's flood form	Three answers, yes or no
Flood insurance quote	From your agent
Policy start date	On or before closing day

Sources

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22. FEMA, NFIP's pricing approach (Risk Rating 2.0)
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23. City of Sarasota, Flood information
www.sarasotafl.gov/Department-Pages/Development-Services/Flood-Information

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26. 44 CFR 61.11, effective date and time of NFIP coverage (Legal Information Institute)
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This guide is general information about places and rules, written for Lakewood Ranch · Sarasota · Bradenton. It is not legal, insurance or tax advice, and nothing in it is a figure for any particular house.

JJ

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Coldwell Banker Realty

Send us an address.

We'll look up the flood zone and the county's records for that house and go through them with you. If you'd rather do it yourself, this guide is the order we'd do it in.

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